



YOU ARE **29 WEEKS AND 4 DAYS**

73 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

In this image a hand is held up to the forehead and, to the right, part of a foot can be seen. The groove between the nose and the upper lip is visible and the nose has the characteristic “button” shape. It looks cramped in there but there is still room to move.

“Your baby is cushioned in a sac of amniotic fluid, which surrounds them until your water breaks and you go into labor.”

As your uterus has enlarged throughout your pregnancy, the amniotic sac has expanded to accommodate both your baby and the amniotic fluid. From now on, however, the sac will grow by simply stretching rather than forming new cells.

The amniotic sac is formed from two distinct layers or membranes, an inner “amnion” and outer “chorion.” The chorion originally had a blood supply of its own, but this has now been lost. The thinner amnion is able to slide over the chorion as your baby pushes against it. Neither layer contains nerve cells: this explains why it’s not painful when your membranes rupture or “water breaks.” Combined, the layers are only 0.5 mm thick. Collagen fibers in each layer allow for a great deal of stretch—this is vital in these final months to avoid early rupture of the membranes. Indeed, the membranes may be so resistant to rupture that they don’t break until the final stages of your labor (see [Water breaking](#)).

In addition to holding in the amniotic fluid and providing a barrier to possible infection through the cervix, the membranes contain substances that form prostaglandins. Prostaglandins play an important part in the initiation of labor. This is one of the reasons why labor often starts when the membranes have ruptured.

THE SEX OF THE BABY

There is no test that will guarantee the sex of your baby, unless you are having an amniocentesis or CVS for some other reason (see [Diagnostic tests](#)). An ultrasound scan can get it wrong, and, despite the old belief, the size and shape of your belly are not good indicators of the gender. The new [NIPT](#) is the best noninvasive way to determine the sex.

FOCUS ON PARTNERS

By now, it’s possible to see and feel your baby moving, often with kicks and punches. This may happen more often in the evenings, when your partner finally gets to sit down and relax. Watching your baby’s movements can be a great way to bond with them, and with your partner.